alcohol, ‘It is very strong. If you wet your hands with it and hold them near the fire, the spirit will burn in flames of different colours without injuring the hands.’[65])

It seems a stretch to deduce murderous intent from a drinking habit, but Badauni insists it was so. Akbar, ill and delirious, cried out, ‘Baba Shaikhu ji, since all this Sultanate will devolve on thee, why Hast thou made this attack on me: To take away my life there was no need of injustice, I would have given it to thee, if thou hadst asked me.’

As Akbar’s health deteriorated and his suspicions grew, Badauni writes that Salim put his men to spy on Murad – with the intent, clearly, of keeping his brother away from the throne, should it fall vacant all of a sudden.

When Akbar recovered, he decided to put some distance between the brothers; and also, possibly, to give Murad a chance to prove his abilities. If the reams of advice that Akbar bestowed on his son before sending him off to Malwa is anything to go by, Akbar wanted Murad to succeed. ‘Let not difference of religion interfere with policy’; ‘If apologies be made, accept them’; ‘Do not make ease your rule’; ‘. . . live so that the crowds of foreigners be not distressed. Especially see to it that merchants have a good opinion of you for their report carries far’; ‘Expect from every one service according to his ability’; ‘Secure the affection of the contented hermits and of the matted-haired and barefooted’; ‘Apply yourself to sympathise with the soldier’; ‘Do not lose sight of an old servant’; ‘Choose a good companion and be not offended at his truthful speech’.[66] Murad was to represent the emperor, to rule in his stead and with his tenets; to prepare, perhaps, to step into his shoes.

Murad welcomed his father’s advice. Abul Fazl, who was sent to explain Akbar’s instructions to Murad, and emphasize how their physical separation was, in fact, a ‘spiritual union’ between father and son, reports a ‘confidential meeting’ between the two men, at which Murad ‘uttered pleasing words’ that ‘delighted’ Akbar.[67] Some sources indicate that Murad’s flattering queries ranged from which days he should fast on to how he should ‘regulate his time of sleep’ – and, in a possibly arch aspersion on his brother, how he should ‘check drunkenness among his followers’.[68]

Was Murad glad, on the whole, for a chance to hold his own, independent court far from the emperor’s critical gaze? He may have been quite pleased